

CASTE ARITHMETIC
Bihar cabinet ministers take the oath of office in Patna, May 7

Takeaways

- **Samrat cabinet has five EBCs, three OBCs, two Dalits, six general**
- **With a Kushwaha at helm, BJP making a play for Nitish's EBC base**
- **Nishant, with Health, has to perform to give JD(U) health insurance**

▶ BIHAR

CONTINUITY IN A CHANGED FORM

The new-look Samrat cabinet is in, with Nishant Kumar in the mix: a compact tinted by competition. Now Bihar awaits governance

Nitish, the BJP was doing a Nitish on Nitish, so to speak.

The driving logic is clear: EBCs constitute over a third of Bihar's population. The BJP is seeking to move into that vast backwards spectrum, hitherto occupied by the 'Janata parivar', broadening its social base—with Samrat, a Koeri or Kushwaha, as the face. Even if it has to happen at the expense of its ally, the Janata Dal (United), or JD(U).

NISHANT'S BIG TEST

For JD(U), this is the first time in over two decades that Nitish is not at an active force in government, receding to the role of a *margdarshak*. Seeking to fill that gap is his son Nishant, now inducted as health minister. If Nitish's political estate can be transferred, even partially, via lineage, the party may retain its relevance in a rapidly shifting landscape. Easier said than done, though. Nishant commands a measure of goodwill, but not authority. He begins entirely without the long history of political immersion Nitish had when he rose to the top. What he has instead is expectation—more of a burden.

The portfolio sharpens the stakes. Health is not a department that permits leisurely acclimatisation. Governance has to be encountered directly, with all its practical complexities, entailing an oversight of public hospitals, medicine availability, public health management, primary care. These often form the everyday interface between citizen and state. In short, an unforgiving arena for apprenticeship. Nishant being able to pull off the job with a degree of measurable success, and public endorsement, will be critical if the JD(U) wishes to retain its identity amidst pressure, in a shifting political terrain. The situation also puts into sharp relief the absence of a viable second line of leadership in the JD(U)—a situation where they had to make a choice out of a compulsion.

That sub-plot unfolds within Samrat's own political project, as he sets about activating his own governance profile. He has kept Home, General Administration, Cabinet Secretariat and Vigilance, so that firm rhetoric on law and order now has space for play. ■